

BEFORE

The first settlements that developed from villages to towns were in modern-day Iraq. The change took place over a long period.

THE HALAFIANS

In what is now northern Iraq, the **Halafian culture** flourished after 6000 BCE. **Long-distance trade** of volcanic glass and brightly painted pots was one of the factors that led to larger villages and towns and to greater **contact between settlements**. Female figurines, like the one shown here, are characteristic of this society.

MESOPOTAMIA

Mesopotamia, which was also part of Iraq, was settled by village farmers as early as 6000 BCE. The communities living in the

south relied on long-distance trade for many commodities, and on **irrigation and wetland agriculture**. By 3500 BCE many southerners lived in growing towns—precursors of Mesopotamian cities **54–55 >>**.

MORE COMPLEX SOCIETIES

By 4000 BCE, village life in southwestern and east Asia was firmly established.

Farming communities became larger and more organized.

Society became more stratified, with a growing social chasm between the rulers and the ruled.

HALAF FIGURINE



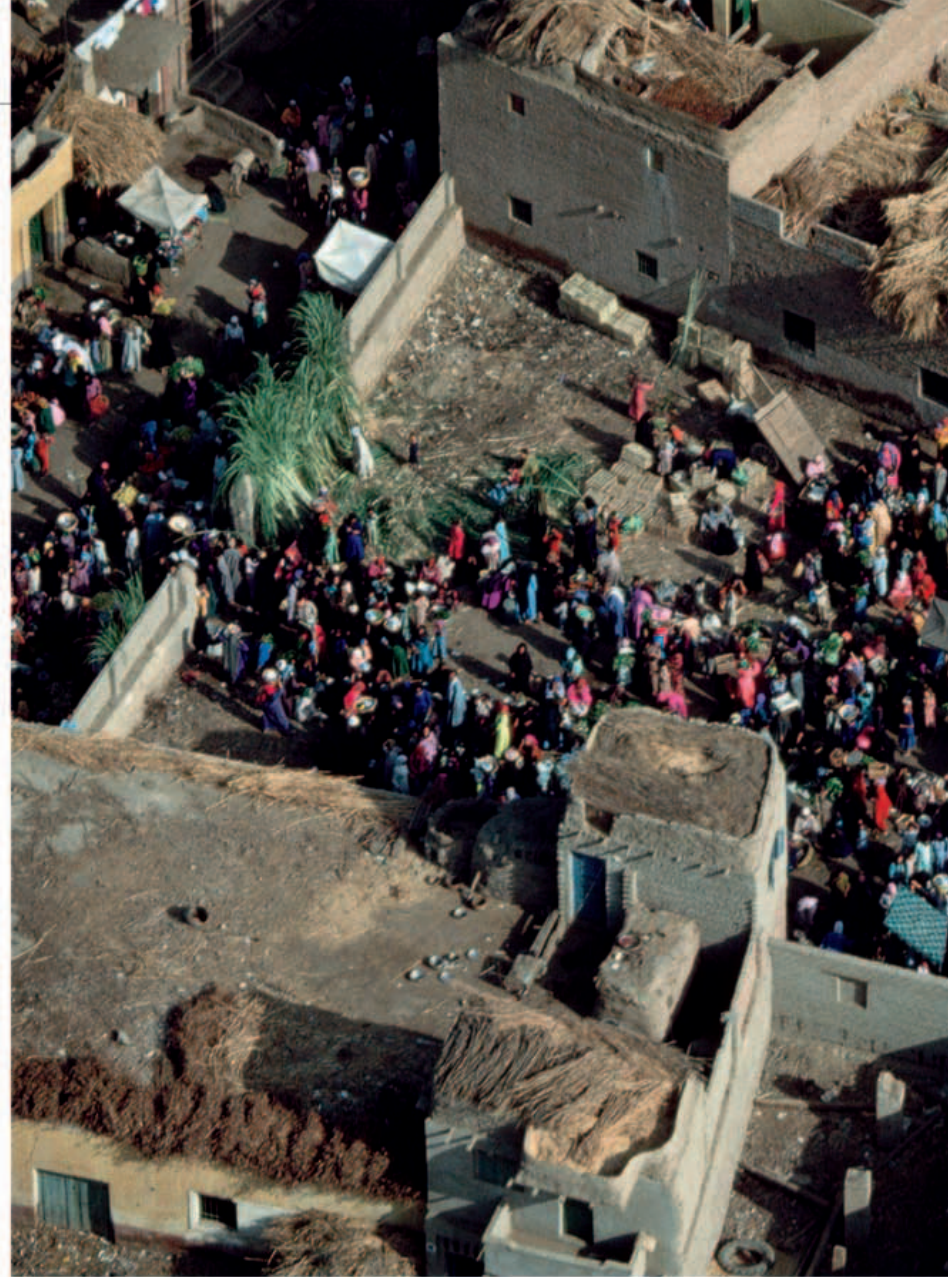
Treasure from Iraq

Naked men bearing offerings of fruit and vegetables approach the shrine of the goddess Innin (Inanna), an Earth goddess, on a carved stone vase of 3000 BCE found in her temple at Uruk. In 2003, looters stole the vase from the Iraq Museum in Baghdad; it was later recovered.



Egyptian market

Village markets with their visiting traders were a major part of community life at a time when all information was exchanged by word of mouth, and merchants brought news of the outside world. This modern-day Egyptian village is little different from the first villages thousands of years ago.



INVENTION

THE WHEEL

The wheel originated in Mesopotamia in the 5th century BCE and is believed to have developed from the potter's wheel. It is one of the most important inventions in human history as it revolutionized transport. By the 3rd millennium the use of wheels had spread east, where burials with wheeled carts took place. Chariots pulled by domesticated horses came into use in the Black Sea region of Europe and northern Mesopotamia after 3000 BCE and became valued by armies on the move. The scene below shows wagons with solid wheels and is taken from the Sumerian Royal Standard of Ur dating to c.2600 BCE.



Town Planning

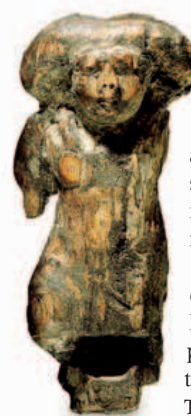
Four thousand years after agriculture began, many farming villages in southwest Asia had grown into towns with over a thousand inhabitants. In southern Iraq, Egypt, and elsewhere, a few strategically placed communities became towns with neighborhoods, public buildings, and sacred precincts.

The world's earliest towns developed in Mesopotamia, perhaps as the result of a need to organize the construction of irrigation channels and canals fed by the Tigris and Euphrates rivers. At first, the towns were little more than agglomerations of villages and related families, but they soon became major centers of trade and vast irrigation works that transformed the countryside and produced several crops a year. Each clustered around temples and sacred precincts built on top of mud brick pyramids called ziggurats.

Uruk and Eridu

Uruk was the earliest Mesopotamian town and developed its initial phase between 4800–3800 BCE. By 2800 BCE

Uruk's town core covered an estimated 620 acres (250 hectares) and housed at least 5,000 people, with many more living in nearby villages. Its rulers governed satellite villages extending at least 6 miles (10 km) from the temple, but most people lived in the town, partly for protection, and also because everything was governed from the center. The growing town was the hub of major trade networks that brought metals, lumber, and other commodities from the highlands far upstream, in exchange for grain from the south's fertile soils. Uruk may even have maintained outlying colonies as far



Nekhen votive

An ivory statue from Nekhen in Upper Egypt depicts an early ruler wearing a ceremonial headdress.

away as the Zagros Mountains, several hundred miles to the north, to ensure control of major trade routes.

Eridu was another early town close to Uruk. Mesopotamian legends called Eridu the dwelling place of Enki, God of the Abyss, the fountain of human wisdom.

The people believed that Enki had created order from the chaos of primordial waters. In its heyday, around 5,000 years ago, Eridu lay in a fertile landscape near the coast. Archaeologists have deciphered the complex history of